

Recruitment Email

Subject: Call for Participants: Study on Teaching Undergrads with Data in the Social Sciences

Dear Professor [First Name],

The UCSB Library is conducting a study on the practices of social science instructors in order to improve support services for their work. We are interviewing instructors whose undergraduate students engage with quantitative data, such as by conducting research using quantitative methods, analyzing or visualizing datasets, or learning to use specific tools or software to work with data.

Your name was selected by referral or because you have recently taught a class that is in scope with this project. Would you be willing to participate in a one-hour interview over Zoom to share your unique experiences and perspective?

Our local UCSB study is part of a suite of parallel studies at 19 other institutions of higher education in the US, coordinated by Ithaka S+R, a not-for-profit research and consulting service. The information gathered at UCSB will also be included in a landmark capstone report by Ithaka S+R and will be essential for UCSB to further understand how the support needs of social science instructors are evolving more broadly.

If you're interested in participating in this study, please contact us in the next two weeks. However, if you are unwilling or unable to participate at this time, we would welcome any suggestions you have of other contacts in your department or on campus. Thank you so much for your consideration. If you have any questions about the study, please don't hesitate to reach out.

Sincerely,

Renata Curty, Research Data Specialist - Social Sciences, rcurty@ucsb.edu

Rebecca Greer, Interim Director of Teaching & Learning, rgreer@ucsb.edu

Torin White, Data Services & Digital Scholarship Librarian, whitet@ucsb.edu

Interview Instructions & Questions

Read:

Note regarding COVID-19 disruption: I want to start by acknowledging that teaching and learning has been significantly disrupted in the past months due to the pandemic. For any of the questions I'm about to ask, please feel free to answer with reference to your normal teaching practices, your teaching practices as adapted for the crisis situation, or both.

Background

I would like to start listening about your experience teaching undergraduate students.

Could you briefly describe your experience teaching undergraduates, including:

- » How does your teaching relate to your current or past research?
- » In which of the courses that you teach do students work with data?

Getting Data

In your course(s), how do your students usually obtain the data they engage with? (collect or generate themselves, search and identify pre-existing data, or you provide them the data sets)?

- Do your students collect or generate data sets, search for and select pre-existing data sets to work with, or work with data sets that you provide to them?
- **If more than one method - what's the primary method?**
- **Could you describe the general process students go through?**
- **Do you face any challenges relating to students' abilities to find data?**

If students collect or generate data sets themselves Describe the process students go through to collect or generate data sets in your course(s).

- » Do you face any challenges relating to students' abilities to find or create data sets?

If students search for pre-existing data sets themselves: Describe the process students go through to locate and select data sets.

- » Do you provide instruction to students in how to find and/or select appropriate data sets to work with?
- » Do you face any challenges relating to students' abilities to find and/or select appropriate data sets?

If students work with data sets the instructor provides: Describe the process students go through to access the data sets you provide. *Examples: link through LMS, instructions for downloading from database*

- » How do you find and obtain data sets to use in teaching?
- » Do you face any challenges in finding or obtaining data sets for teaching?

Working with Data

How do students manipulate, analyze, or interpret data in your course(s)?

- » What **tools or software** do your students use? *Examples: Excel, online platforms, analysis/visualization/statistics software*
- » What **prior knowledge of tools or software do you expect students to have**, and **what do you teach them explicitly?**
- » **To what extent** are the tools or software students use to work with data **important for your teaching?**
- » **Do you face any challenges relating to students' abilities to work with data?**

How do the ways in which you teach with data relate to the learning goals in your field?

- » Do you teach your students to **think critically about the sources and uses of data they encounter in everyday life?**
- » Do you teach your students **specific data skills** that will prepare them for future careers?

Do instructors in your field face any **ethical challenges** in teaching with data?

- » To what extent are these challenges **important to your teaching?**

Have you observed any policies or cultural changes here at UCSB that influence the ways in which you teach with data?

Training and Support

In your course(s), **does anyone other than you provide instruction or support for your students in obtaining or working with data?** *Examples: co-instructor, librarian, teaching assistant, drop-in sessions*

- » How does their instruction or support relate to the rest of the course?
- » Do you communicate with them about the instruction or support they are providing? If so, how?

To your knowledge, are there any ways in which your students are **learning to work with data outside their formal coursework?** *Examples: online tutorials, internships, peers*

- » Do you expect or encourage this kind of extracurricular learning? Why or why not? If so, how?

Your own training

Have you received training in teaching with data other than your graduate degree?

Examples: workshops, technical support, help from peers

- » What factors have influenced your decision to receive/not to receive training or assistance?
- » Do you **use any data sets, assignment plans, syllabi, or other instructional resources** that you received from others? Do you make your own **resources available to others**?

Considering evolving trends in your field, what types of training or assistance would be most beneficial to instructors in teaching with data?

Wrapping Up

Is there anything else from your experiences or perspectives as an instructor, or on the topic of teaching with data more broadly, that you would like to share?